

0.0.1 The Triple Knowledge (excerpt)

1. Thus was heard by me:
At one time the Auspicious One was wandering on tour in Kosala with a large Sangha of bhikkhus, with about five hundred bhikkhus, when they arrived at a brahmin village of the Kosalans named Manasakata. There the Auspicious One dwelled at a mango grove north of Manasakata on the bank of the Aciravati river.

2. At that time many well-known wealthy brahmins were dwelling at Manasakata, such as: the brahmin Canki, the brahmin Tarukkha, the brahmin Pokkharasati, the brahmin Janussoṇi, the brahmin Todeyya, and many other well-known and wealthy

tevijjasuttam (excerpt)

evammesutam: ekam samayaṃ bhagavā kosalesu cārikaṃ caramāno mahatā bhikkhusaṅghena saddhiṃ pañcamatehi bhikkhusatehi yena manasākaṭaṃ nāma kosalānaṃ brāhmaṇagāmo tadavasari. tatra su-
dam bhagavā manasākaṭe viharati uttarena manasākaṭassa aciravatiyā nadiyā tīre ambavane.

tena kho pana samayena sambahulā abhiññātā abhiññātā brāhmaṇamahāsālā manasākaṭe paṭivasanti, seyyathidaṃ: caṅkī brāhmaṇo, tārukko brāhmaṇo, pokkharasātī brāhmaṇo, jāṇussoṇī brāh-

brahmins.

3. Now for Vasettha and Bharadvaja, while walking and wandering about, walking along back and forth, this topic of conversation about path and non-path arose. Then the brahmin youth Vasettha said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.”

4. The brahmin youth Bharadvaja said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this

maṇo, todeyyo brāhmaṇo, aññe ca abhiññātā abhiññātā brāhmaṇamahāsālā.

atha kho vāseṭṭha-bhāradvājānaṃ jaṅghāvihāraṃ anucaṅkamantānaṃ anuvarantānaṃ maggāmagge kathā udapādi. atha kho vāseṭṭho māṇavo evamāha: ‘ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena pokkharasātinā’ti.

bhāradvājo māṇavo evamāha: ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena tārukkhenā’ti.

[path] declared by the brahmin Tarukkha.” Neither was the brahmin youth Vasettha able to convince the brahmin youth Bharadvaja, nor was the brahmin youth Bharadvaja able to convince the brahmin youth Vasettha.

5. So then, the brahmin youth Vasettha address the brahmin youth, Bharadvaja. Master Bharadvaja, there is this samana Gotama, son of the Sakyans who has gone forth from the Sakyan clan, dwelling at Manasakata, in a mango grove north of Manasakata on the bank of the Aciravati river. Now a good reputation has been spread about that Auspicious Gotama thus: “Truly is he the Auspicious One, the Arahant, rightly self-awakened, excelling in knowledge and conduct, well-farer, knower of worlds, incomparable charioteer of tamed per-

neva khvāsakkhi¹
vāseṭṭho māṇavo
bhāradvājaṃ māṇa-
vaṃ saññāpetuṃ. na
pañāsakkhi bhāra-
dvājo māṇavo vāseṭ-
ṭhaṃ māṇavaṃ sañ-
ñāpetuṃ.

atha kho vāseṭṭho
māṇavo bhāradvā-
jaṃ māṇavaṃ āman-
tesi: ayaṃ kho bhā-
radvāja, samaṇo go-
tamo sakyaputto sa-
kyakulā pabbajito
manasākaṭe viharati
uttarena manasāka-
ṭassa aciravatiyā na-
diyā tīre ambavane.
taṃ kho pana bha-
vantaṃ gotamaṃ
evaṃ kalyāṇo kitti-
saddo abbhuggato:
itipi so bhagavā ara-
haṃ sammāsambud-
dho vijjācaraṇasam-
panno sugato loka-
vidū anuttaro pu-
risadammasārathi

sons, teacher of devas and humans, awakened, auspicious.” We must visit with the samana Gotama, O Master Bharadvaja. Upon arrival, we must ask the samana Gotama about this matter. In which ever way the samana Gotama will answer, in just that way we must bear it in mind.” “Yes sir.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja replied to the brahmin youth Vasettha.

6. So then, the brahmin youths Vasettha and Bharadvaja visited with the Auspicious One. Having approached, they exchanged friendly greetings with the Auspicious One. Having exchanged friendly greetings and cordial talk, they sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the

satthā devamanus-sānaṃ buddho bhagavā’ti. āyāma bho bhāradvāja, yena samaṇo gotamo tenupasaṅkamissāma. upasaṅkamitvā etamatthaṃ samaṇaṃ gotamaṃ pucchissāma. yathā no samaṇo gotamo byākarissati, tathā naṃ dhāressāmāti. ‘evambho’ti kho bhāradvājo māṇavo vāseṭṭhassa māṇavassa paccassosi.

atha kho vāseṭṭhabhāradvājā māṇavā yena bhagavā tenu-pasaṅkamaṃsu. upasaṅkamitvā bhagavatā saddhiṃ sammodaṃsu. sammodaṇīyaṃ kathaṃ sārāṇīyaṃ vītisāretvā ekamantaṃ nisīdiṃsu. ekamantaṃ nisinna kho vāseṭṭha-

brahmin youth Vasettha said this to the Auspicious One: “Here Master Gotama, for us while walking and wandering about, walking along back and forth, this topic of conversation about path and non-path arose. I said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Tarukkha.” Here Master Gotama, there is really a dispute, there is a contention, there is a difference of views.”

ṭho māṇavo bhagavantaṃ etadavoca: “idha bho gotama amhākaṃ jaṅghā-vihāraṃ anucaṅka-mantānaṃ anuvicarantānaṃ maggā-magge kathā udapādi. ahaṃ evaṃ vadāmi: ‘ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena pokkharasātinā’ti. bhāradvājo māṇavo evamāha: ‘ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena tārukkenā’ti. ettha bho gotama, attheva viggaho atthi vivādo, atthi nānāvādo”ti.

“iti kira vāseṭṭha,

7. Thus apparently, O Vasettha, you say thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja say thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Tarukkha.” But what, O Vasettha, is your dispute, what is the contention, what is the difference of views?”

8. “About path and non-path, O Master Gotama. Even though, O Master Gotama, the brahmins declare various paths: that of the Addhariya brahmins, the Tittiriya brahmins, the Chandoka brah-

tvam evam vadesi: ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena pokkharasātinā’ti. bhāradvājo māṇavo evamāha: ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya yvāyaṃ akkhāto brāhmaṇena tārukkenāti. atha kismiṃ pana vo vāsetṭhā viggaho? kismiṃ vivādo? kismiṃ nānāvādo?”ti.

“maggāmagge bho gotama. kiñcāpi bho gotama brāhmaṇā nānāmagge paññāpenti addhariyā brāhmaṇā, tittiriya brāhmaṇā. chandokā brāhmaṇā, bavhi-

mins, the Bavhirica brahmins, they all lead to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma. Just as, O Master Gotama, not too far from a village or market town, even if there are various paths, all converge on the village. So too, O Master Gotama, even though the brahmins declare various paths: that of the Addhariya brahmins, the Tittiriya brahmins, the Chandoka brahmins, the Bavhirica brahmins, they all lead to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma.”

ricā¹ brāhmaṇā, atha kho sabbāni tāni niyyāṇikāni niyyanti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāya. seyya-thāpi bho gotama gāmassa vā niga-massa vā avidūre bahūni cepi nānā-maggāni bhavanti, atha kho sabbāni tāni gāmasamosaraṇāni bhavanti. evameva kho bho gotama kiñcāpi brāhmaṇā nānāmagge paññāpentī addhāriyā brāhmaṇā, tittiriyā brāhmaṇā, chandokā brāhmaṇā, bavhīricā brāhmaṇā, atha kho sabbāni tāni niyyāṇikāni niyyanti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāyā”ti.

9. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

“niyyantīti vāseṭṭha vadesi?”

10. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

“niyyantīti bho gotama vadāmi”.

11. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

“niyyantīti vāsetṭha vadesi?”

12. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

“niyyantīti bho gotama vadāmi”.

13. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

“niyyantīti vāsetṭha vadesi?”

14. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

“niyyantīti bho gotama vadāmi”.

15. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma?”

“kiṃ pana vāsetṭha, atthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ eka-brāhmaṇo’pi yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho?”ti.

16. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

“no hidaṃ bho gotama”.

17. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is

“kiṃ pana vāsetṭha, atthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ ekā-

there even one teacher who is able to see Brahma?"

cariyo'pi yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho?"ti.

18. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

"no hidaṃ bho gotama".

19. "But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma?"

"kiṃ pana vāseṭṭha, atthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ ekā-cariyapācariyo'pi yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho?"ti.

20. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

"no hidaṃ bho gotama".

21. "But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma?"

"kiṃ pana vāseṭṭha, atthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ yāva sattamā ācariyama-hayugā yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho?"ti.

22. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

"no hidaṃ bho gotama".

23. "But how about this, O Vasettha. Even the an-

"kiṃ pana vāseṭṭha, ye'pi tevijjānaṃ brāh-

cient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeating what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: At-taka, Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, do they even speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].”

24. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

25. Thus apparently, O

mañānaṃ pubbakā isayo mantānaṃ kat-tāro mantānaṃ pavattāro yesamidaṃ etarahi tevijjā brāhmaṇā porāṇaṃ man-tapadaṃ gītaṃ pavuttaṃ samūhitaṃ tadanugāyanti tadanubhāsanti bhāsitaṃ manubhāsanti vācitaṃ manuvācenti, seyyathidaṃ: atṭako vāmako vāmadevo vessāmitto yamataggi aṅgīraso bhāradvājo vāseṭṭho kassapo bhagu, te’pi evamāhaṃsu: maya-metaṃ jānāma mayametaṃ passāma yattha vā brahmā yena vā brahmā ya-hiṃ vā brahmā’ti?”.

“no hidaṃ bho gotama”.

iti kira vāseṭṭha nat-

Vasettha, among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma.

26. Apparently, even the ancient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeat-

thi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ eka-brāhmaṇopi yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho. natthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ ekācariyopi yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho. natthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ ekācariyapācariyopi yena brahmā sakkhidiṭṭho. natthi koci tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ yāva sattamā ācariyama-hayugā yena brahmā sakkhi diṭṭho -

yepi kira tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ pubbakā isayo mantānaṃ kattāro mantānaṃ pavattāro, yesamidaṃ etarahi tevijjā brāhmaṇā porānaṃ mantapadaṃ gītaṃ pavuttaṃ samūhitaṃ tadanugāyanti tadanubhāsanti bhā-

ing what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: Attaka, Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, even they do not speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].” Surely those triple-knowledge brahmins who speak thus: “We teach the path to union with that which we do not know, to that which we do not see, this is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma.”

27. “So what do you think, O Vasettha, that being so,

sitamanubhāsanti vācitamanuvācenti, seyyathīdaṃ: aṭṭako vāmako vāmadevo vessāmitto yamataggi aṅgirasso bhāradvājo vāseṭṭho kassapo bhagu, tepi na evamāhaṃsu: mayametam jānāma mayametam passāma yattha vā brahmā yena vā brahmā ya-hiṃ vā brahmāti. te vata tevijjā brāhmaṇā evamāhaṃsu: yaṃ mayaṃ na jānāma yaṃ na passāma, tassa saha-vyatāya maggaṃ desema: ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāti takkarassa brahmasahavyatāyāti.

taṃ kimmaññasi vāseṭṭha, tanu evaṃ sante tevijjānaṃ brāh-

doesn't the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar?"

28. "Certainly, O Master Gotama, that being so, the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar."

29. Good Vasettha. Indeed O Vasettha, that those triple-knowledge brahmins [could] teach a path to union with that which they do not know, that which they do not see, [claiming]: "This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma," this possibility is not to be found. Just as, O Vasettha, a line of blind men go on in succession holding on to each other, the first one does not see, the middle one too does

maṇānaṃ appāṭihī-rakataṃ bhāsitaṃ sampajjati?ti.

addhā kho bho gotama, evaṃ sante tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ appāṭihīrakataṃ bhāsitaṃ sampajjati.

sādhū vāseṭṭha. te vata vāseṭṭha tevijjā brāhmaṇā yaṃ na jānanti yaṃ na passanti tassa saḥavyatāya maggaṃ desessanti: ayameva ujumaggo ayamañjasāyano niyyāṇiko niyyāni takkarassa brahmasaḥavyatāyāti netam ṭhānaṃ vijjati. seyyathāpi vāseṭṭha andhaveṇi-paramparaṃ sam-sattā purimopi na passati majjhimopi na passati pacchi-

not see, the last one too does not see. So too, O Vasettha, the statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins seem to me like a line of blind men; the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. These statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be mere speech, turn out to be mere words, turn out to be simply empty, turn out to be simply hollow.

mopi na passati, evameva kho vāseṭṭha andhaveṇūpamaṃ maññe tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ bhāsitaṃ. purimopi na passati. majjhimopi na passati. pacchimopi na passati. te-samidaṃ tevijjānaṃ brāhmaṇānaṃ bhāsitaṃ bhassakaññeva sampajjati, nāmakaññeva sampajjati. rit-takaññeva sampajjati, tucchakaññeva sampajjati.

